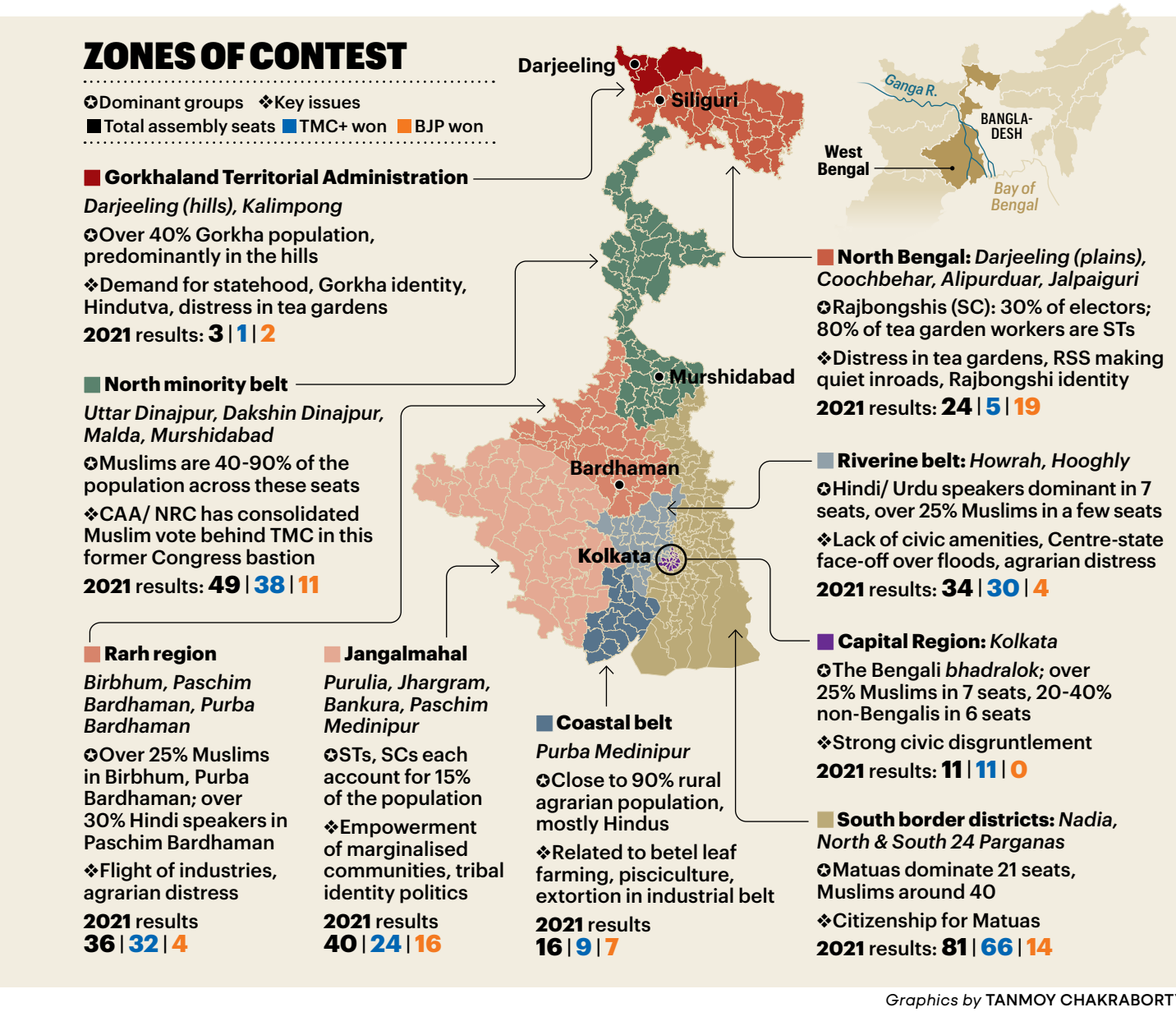


Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

Mamata is projecting herself not just as the defender of the Bengali identity but also as a victim of the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in her state

by the BJP-led central government to split the state—either trifurcating it, or merging parts with neighbouring regions to dilute its identity and electoral strength— harking back to past statements by BJP leaders and public representatives arguing that North Bengal and Jangalmahal be made separate states. Post election, she says, the BJP will launch Operation Lotus, poaching TMC legislators if it falls short of a majority.

The SIR Setback

Electorally, Mamata begins with a structural advantage of a consolidated minority base. Muslims, who made up 27.01 per cent of Bengal's population in 2011, are now estimated to exceed 30 per cent. They have largely rallied around Mamata since the 2021 assembly election, a consolidation shaped by the fears around the Citizenship (Amendment) Act and the National Register of Citizens. In 2021, of the 74 constituencies with Muslim populations ranging between 40 and 90 per cent—including Malda, Murshidabad, Uttar and Dakshin Dinajpur, the 24 Parganas, Kolkata, Howrah, Purba Bardhaman and Birbhum—the TMC won 71. But it also won 27 of the 49 constituencies that had more than 90 per cent Hindu voters (the remaining 22 going to the BJP), demonstrating that a substantial section of Hindus remains resistant to the more aggressive Hindutva appeals of the BJP.

The SIR, though, may have complicated calculations now. Over 9.1 million names have been deleted in the revision of electoral rolls. Two of TMC's core vote banks—women and Muslims—have been disproportionately affected. Under the Absent, Shifted, Dead and Deleted categories, some 3.1 million female voter names have been deleted compared